In order to better understand the way such ideas about Islam were being justified and whether similar things were being said elsewhere in the country, colleagues and I began the M.MAS Research Project in January 2015.[5] Over the next four months, one colleague and I conducted sixty-eight interviews with seventy-eight people in six cities: Sittwe, Meiktila, Mandalay, Lashio, Pathein, and Mawlamyine.[6] The majority of those we interviewed were Buddhist, but we also interviewed people from the other three major world religious traditions in Myanmar (Muslim, Hindu, Christian). Our interviews were arranged by local youth activists, who helped us select people with an eye to a diversity of gender, educational, and class perspectives. We conducted our interviews in Burmese and arranged translations only when, in a few cases, we spoke with individuals who felt more comfortable speaking in another local language.[7]

We strove to make our interview encounters open-ended and thus initiated only basic questions about people's lives, livelihoods, and their concerns. We did not ask specifically about issues related to religion or conflict. Instead, we approached the research as a "listening project".[8] After initial biographical information was discussed, we asked people to reflect on their primary concerns for their communities and for the country, and then to rank these concerns. In each case we would ask a series of probing questions about the issues they selected as their primary concerns, which ranged from topics including health and education to democracy or civil war. This enabled us to understand the nature of their concerns, with whom they discussed these issues, where they sought related news and information, and how long they had felt this way. While not everyone raised communal conflict as their primary concern, it was rare for the issue not to come up, though the issue was, as might be expected, more salient in areas that had experienced riotous violence than in areas that had not.

It is important to say at the outset that while nearly everyone raised concern about communal conflict, not everyone in Myanmar directs fear and antagonism towards Muslims. Where I lived in western Yangon, for example, friends who expressed such feelings about Islam have friends and co-workers who are Muslim, and have happily participated in campaigns to promote interfaith peace. The brothers mentioned above, for example, have had on their front door — for two years now — a sticker bearing the message "I will not be the cause of racial or religious violence." In the M.MAS listening project, meanwhile, we interviewed people who articulated strong senses of felt contradiction between current tensions and